

English Gothic

Gothic in Britain absorbed influences from other parts of Europe – as can be seen in its pointed arches, vaulted roofs, buttresses, large windows, tracery and spires – and yet its relative insularity resulted in a uniquely British synthesis. As they had done with the preceding Norman (Romanesque) style, masons and craftsmen introduced ideas from France to England, where Gothic was retrospectively divided into three periods: Early English (1200–75), Decorated (1275–1375) and Perpendicular (1375–1520).

An Early English example is the choir of Canterbury Cathedral (opposite), rebuilt in Gothic style after a fire in 1174. Salisbury Cathedral (1220–58) is also in the Early English style; the west front, although decorated, is flat and plain in comparison with its flamboyant French counterparts. Other Early English examples include Westminster Abbey, largely rebuilt in 1245 and 1269, and the late 12th-century Galilee chapel at Durham Cathedral, with slender columns supporting highly decorated arches.

